BRIDGING CULTURAL GAPS BETWEEN HIGHER EDUCATION AND DIVERSITY

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Abstract

This paper addresses challenges and contradictions between the culture of higher education and the cultures of diverse students. Significant gaps in student success are cause for serious concern in higher education. Responses to this concern include various diversity initiatives. A general overview of the culture of higher education and the new student demographic is presented, followed by a summary of common diversity initiatives. A culture-centric model is presented as a framework for comprehensive *institutional transformation* to reduce the cultural gap.

Key words: culture of higher education, institutional transformation, student diversity

The gap between the culture of higher education and the cultures of an increasingly diverse student population negatively impacts student engagement and success. Building on the work of developmental psychologist Urie Bronfenbrenner (1994:1645), I suggest that both the students' home cultures and the culture of higher education can be considered *microsystems*, which are defined as:

> …a pattern of activities, social roles, and interpersonal relations experienced by the developing person in a given face-to-face setting with particular physical, social, and symbolic features that invite, permit, or inhibit engagement in sustained, progressively more complex interactions with, and activity in, the immediate environment.

The *developing person* noted in this case is the university student. Within both microsystems, there are rules, values, and roles which need to be understood to function successfully. Critical *proximal processes* within microsystems capture the quality and power of interactions that contribute to one's development, whether those interactions occur with people or other aspects within the environment (Bronfenbrenner and Morris 2007).

Accordingly, the culture of higher education is manifested through the people, practices, and environment. To demonstrate the cultural gap, I describe traits within the "culture of higher education" followed by an overview of the increasingly diverse student population. Following my summary of common diversity initiatives, I propose a culture-centric model as a framework for *institutional transformation* to reduce this cultural gap.

The Culture of Higher Education

There are over 4,000 institutions of higher education in the United States ranging from private, for-profit to public; and from technical training to liberal arts colleges to research universities. While each institution has its own "cultural ways," there are common values and consistent practices within these microsystems. To frame the *culture of higher education*, I briefly describe the internal infrastructure, external influences, common practices, values and traditions, and common language as cultural traits.

There is little variation in organizational charts of colleges and universities, each having presidents/chancellors, provosts or executive vice presidents, other vice-presidents, deans, directors, and chairs. Academic units include schools, colleges, departments, and divisions. Full-time faculties, ranked by titles, also serve in governance roles through committees and councils. Instruction is also provided by adjunct and visiting faculties. Of all full-time faculty in degree-granting postsecondary institutions in the fall of 2013, 79 percent were White, 10 percent were Asian/Pacific Islander, 6 percent were Black, 5 percent were Hispanic, and less than 1 percent were American Indian/Alaska Native (United States Department of Education, National Center for Education Statistics 2015b). Personnel in residence life, campus life, athletics, and academic enrichment are also dedicated to student support.

Each institution has a formal governing board to whom the president reports. External accrediting bodies evaluate expected practices. External constituencies include individual donors, friends, alumni, and elected officials who have political or vested interests in institutions.

Fundamental institutional values are *academic freedom*, *freedom of speech*, a *code of ethics*, and *academic integrity*. Core values frequently include *student success* and *academic excellence*, with a growing number indicating *diversity* and *inclusion*. Common expectations are that students work independently; are familiar with the catalog, student handbook, and major requirements; and have the academic skills and resources to succeed.

The language in higher education has several unique terms and phrases. Learning this language is essential for successful navigation of the system. Consider, for example: *majors, minors, electives*, and *degree plans*. Add *credit hours*, *semester load, time-to-degree, advisors, mentors, syllabi,* and *supplemental instruction*. Don't forget *prerequisites* and *course substitutions* and processing *grade appeals, withdrawals, incompletes,* and *academic probation*. Decipher net costs using *tuition and fees,* plus course fees, textbook, and software costs, and living expenses minus the *financial aid* package.

The plethora of course options range from face-to-face to *on-line*, with *hybrids* in between. There are *internships, practica, field-based courses*, and *study abroad*. Don't forget *independent* or *directed studies*, and *capstone* courses. The menu also includes *remedial, developmental*, and *honors* options. Courses are offered during traditional *semesters*, summer *terms,* and *mini-mesters*. Learning this terminology and the values, processes, and expected behaviors quickly increases the likelihood for successful navigation.

Reflecting on the "culture of higher education" through these selected cultural traits, this culture is likely in stark contrast to the educational systems and structures that many diverse students experienced in their high schools or home cultures. The enculturation process is often piecemeal, with assumptions that students will recall massive content given during intensive, one-time orientations prior to the beginning of their first semester.

And what about the increased cultural diversity, values, and assets that students bring *to the university*? The diversity is reflected by ethnic, racial, national origin, religious, and language backgrounds. This trend has been steadily increasing in the K-12 system and is increasingly prominent at the postsecondary level. The increasingly diverse student population, however, is not mirrored by the backgrounds of faculty and administrators. Unless there is greater appreciation of the backgrounds and values of diverse students, and there are more culturally relevant and meaningful programs to effectively improve the educational attainment of diverse students, we will continue to see an increased gap in student retention and success in postsecondary education.

Increasingly Diverse Students

The percentages of American college students who are Hispanic, Asian/Pacific Islander, Black, and American Indian/Alaska Native have dramatically increased. From 1976 to 2012, the percentage of Hispanic students rose from 4 to 15 percent, Black students rose from 10 to 15 percent, Asian/Pacific Islander students rose from 2 to 6 percent, and American Indian/Alaska Native students rose from 0.7 to 0.9 percent. During the same period, the percentage of White students fell from 84 to 60 percent (United States Department of Education, National Center for Education Statistics 2015a).

Despite a significant increase in enrollment, the attainment of the first bachelor's degree by students' race and ethnicity is not good. The *Higher Education: Gaps in Access and Persistence Study* reported the percentages of Black (51%) and Hispanic (52%) full-time students at 4-year institutions who attained bachelor's degrees were lower than the percentages of White (73%) and Asian students (76%) who attained a bachelor's degree (United States Department of Education, National Center for Education Statistics 2012).

To what shall we attribute these racial or ethnic differences in success? To the institutions? To the students? Research on campus climate and environments suggests the need to acknowledge negative experiences shared by students of color and the impact this has on student achievement (Gloria and Robinson-Kurpius 2001; Hurtado et.al. 1999). Validation of students' cultures matters, especially to underrepresented students.

Being away from family and the lack of community *within the institution* was found to negatively impact Hispanic student retention and success (Walker and Schultz 2001). Another study revealed that Latinos with higher ethnic identity perceived the university environment more negatively, especially when their cultural heritage was not validated by the university (Castillo et al. 2006). Cultural values for many students of color include sense of belonging, ethnic traditions, family, respect, and hard work or persistence.

Recall the previous data on the racial composition of faculty, with nearly 80 percent being White. Today, students of color are questioning why there are so few faculty of color, particularly among full-time, tenured professors, whether at Hispanic-Serving Institutions (HSIs) or Predominantly White Institutions (PWIs).

As we are witnessing serious educational attainment gaps for students from historically excluded racial and ethnic backgrounds, we are also observing aggressive and targeted efforts in the corporate and public sectors to diversify their personnel (cf. Council for Corporate Responsibility, National Diversity Council). Expanded funding at the state and national levels seek to gain more diverse future scientists through STEM or STEAM programs. Yet, we continue to witness patterns of limited or failed initiatives in postsecondary education intended to improve the educational attainment of students of color.

Common Diversity Initiatives

Common curricular and personnel initiatives designed to promote diversity in higher education are briefly described and critiqued here. Too often these initiatives are poorly designed, marginalized, or targeted to the wrong audiences.

A strong movement in the 1970s contributed to the growth of courses in *ethnic* and *gender studies*. Courses were developed in response to student demands and designed to teach what had been omitted from formal education. Students enrolling in these courses were primarily motivated to learn more about their own backgrounds. These courses were mostly for electives or minors. Some institutions offer majors in these areas, though these programs are often marginalized and underfunded.

At least two decades after the ethnic studies movement, *diversity course* requirements in the general education curriculum were introduced. Proponents of this movement expressed concern about students' lack of understanding and appreciation of diverse experiences and social divisions within the United States. Resistance to acknowledging historical exclusion and oppression resulted in alternative courses such as International Business, Spanish Literature, or Latin American History fulfilling the diversity requirement.

Many pre-professional programs' external accrediting bodies established standards requiring coursework to enhance students' cultural competence to work with diverse clientele. The area of multicultural education for pre-professional teachers, for example, emerged from the recognition of the cultural, racial, and ethnic disconnect between the student population in the schools and the individuals going into teaching.

Another curricular model is the integration of *diversity content* throughout the curriculum. The Association of American Colleges and Universities (2016) proposed a learning outcome of "intercultural knowledge and competence," suggesting this should be developed through an integrative process embedded across the curriculum, rather than within specific *diversity* courses.

With most of these curricular strategies, courses were designed to influence students' understanding and appreciation of cultural diversity. Curricular strategies evolved from marginalized students learning more about their own backgrounds to all students learning more about diverse others, regardless of their background. Less is known about faculty preparation and commitment to teaching diversity courses or content.

The personnel approach to diversity initiatives have primarily targeted recruiting diverse faculty and supporting professional development. With the rich history of Affirmative Action programs and policies, we have come full circle in seeking legitimate strategies to recruit a more diverse faculty. In over thirty years in higher education, I have witnessed several subtle and blatant barriers contributing to the continued *underrepresentation of faculty of color* and highlight three examples here.

Several years ago, I was actively recruited for a faculty position at a research university seeking to increase the faculty of color among the tenured faculty. *Departmental nominations* of Hispanic scholars were solicited. If selected, departments received a newly funded line. Offers were extended to a cohort of eighteen Hispanic scholars. Within three years, two-thirds of this cohort left the institution—including myself. Though faculty in the host departments nominated us, many of them were not pleased with the compensation packages we received (reduced teaching load, summer stipends, and graduate assistants). Many of us experienced a rather hostile work environment within our departments. This initiative was created with the *best of intentions*, though not well designed.

Another potential barrier is the *search committee*. I recall a search committee discussion on the need to hire more diverse faculty. Immediately, one of the members cautioned, "Yes, but they *must* be qualified," assuming applicants of color would not likely meet the minimum qualifications. These same assumptions continue today. This thinking aligns with the racist notion held by some White faculties that faculty of color "need to do twice as much to be considered half as good" as them.

A third barrier to diversity recruitment pertains to the *position announcement* itself. Consider minimal or preferred qualifications likely to attract a more diverse pool: being bilingual, <u>if</u> this skill can be used in teaching, outreach, or program development; having effective teaching or professional experience with underrepresented students or clientele; or having meaningful cultural immersion experiences in professional or voluntary settings. Any applicant, regardless of race or ethnicity, can acquire these skills and experiences, thus these are not unfair advantages. Higher education could afford to learn from organizations such as the Council for Corporate Responsibility (2016:paragraph 1) that claims, "Those companies that insulate themselves from a diverse workforce only serve to insulate themselves from a larger pool of ideas that could ultimately benefit them."

Professional development with the goal of expanded cultural competence is another personnel initiative. The primary need for cultural competence is due, in large part, to the lack of racial and ethnic diversity among the faculty, administration, and staff. Anthropologist Ruth Benedict (1934:10-11) advocated for something similar over eighty years ago:

> The study of different cultures has another important bearing upon present-day thought and behavior. Modern existence has thrown many civilizations into close contact, and at the moment the overwhelming response to this situation is nationalism and racial snobbery. There has never been a time when civilization stood more in need of individuals who are genuinely culture-conscious, who can see objectively the socially conditioned behavior of other peoples….

Recent racial unrest and growing demands from students of color remind us of the violence that erupted more than fifty years ago, when students of color were being admitted to postsecondary institutions after historically being denied. The circumstances are different today, but the demands for inclusion and validation continue. Consequently, the role and responsiveness of leadership is being challenged on a national level, and I strongly believe that *leadership sets the tone* for each institution.

Higher education leadership development programs approach *diversity* in at least three ways. One is to include diversity topics and resources in training programs. Second is to actively recruit participants from historically excluded groups (e.g., women and people of color). Third is to create senior leadership positions such as Vice-Presidents for Diversity, Inclusion, or Equity and have them take the lead in addressing diversity issues on campus.

Unless the leadership development training programs offer *critical dialogues* on the most serious challenges with diversity and invite participants to consider viable, inclusive, and respectful solutions, merely *covering the topics* will not prepare prospective leaders for difficult situations. Secondly, recruiting people of color to leadership roles and assuming we are *inherently* prepared to address diversity issues and topics creates a different type of limitation. Equally problematic is reducing the scope of presumed knowledge and expertise of people of

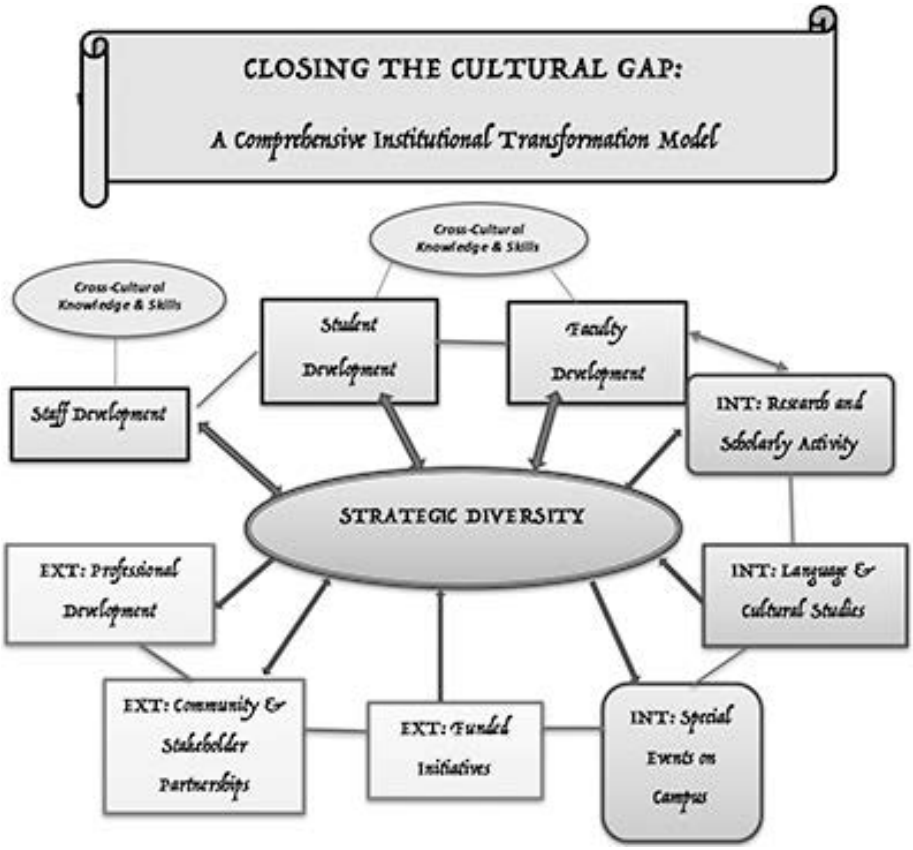

Figure 1. A Comprehensive Institutional Transformation Model to Close the Cultural Gap between the Cultures of Higher Education and Students' Cultures

color to *only* diversity topics, which potentially constricts broader leadership abilities and contributions.

Not to discredit gains made by these various initiatives, my premise is that we need to critique these efforts and redesign programs which can clearly contribute to student success. We can learn from these efforts and initiatives to close the cultural gap. Further, we should acknowledge that we have much to learn from our students and their cultural assets.

Institutional Transformation: A Proposed Cultural Framework

As shared in the introduction, a more comprehensive and strategic approach is needed to bridge the university and diverse students' cultures. Using a cultural framework, I urge shifting the focus to *transforming institutions* rather than students, based on two central themes: (1) *the culture of higher education is substantially disconnected from the cultures of diverse students, and* (2) *institutions* ***can*** *change to be more conducive to student success for diverse students.*

For this systemic institutional transformation, I propose three broad areas upon which to create cultural bridges between the university and diverse students' cultures and to enhance student engagement, retention, and success (see Figure 1). These three areas include: (1) cultural competence of the people through professional development, (2) collaborative culturally-centered internal campus resources and programs, and (3) support from or for external constituencies. Each area is briefly introduced with suggested strategies offered.

Cultural Competence and Professional Development

There is a growing interest and demand for more culturally competent individuals. Cultural competence for students can be promoted in: the classroom, research opportunities, leadership roles, internships, and student employment settings. When *intentionally* addressed in these contexts, there is increased opportunity to gain cultural competence. It is also essential to recognize, acknowledge, and build upon the cultural competence students bring to the university.

Cultural competence for staff and faculty should include cultural content, contexts, and meaningful experiences relevant to the student populations. Examples of effective strategies for developing cultural competence are: domestic or international immersion experiences *with critical reflection* (Aguilar and Pohan 1998); readings by authors of color; diverse students' reflections of their personal challenges and experiences in higher education; and workshops to critique course materials to assess cultural relevance.

Meaningful cross-cultural experiences for personnel will lead to more effective interactions with diverse students in the classroom and in other support services. Transformative cross-cultural skills will also positively influence individuals' contributions to search committees, policy development, and curricular development.

Internal Programs and Campus Events

Three selected areas under internal programs and activities are: research and scholarly activity, academic programs such as language and cultural studies, and special events. Intentional collaboration, with a cultural focus, among the areas of grants and contracts, special collections, academic programs, and special campus events such as institutes and performances is strongly recommended. Collectively, these areas offer diversity resources for the remainder of campus. New degree and certificate programs may also emerge from this synergy.

External Constituencies

Three areas identified for external constituencies include fundraising, external professional development,

and community partnerships. The focus of fundraising is seeking prospective donors to support cultural initiatives for institutional transformation and student success. External professional development initiatives focus on cultural competence development for or by community practitioners, clinicians, and other professionals. Utilizing internal expertise, many institutions are positioned to provide these experiences through continued learning, CEUs, and specialized certifications. Community stakeholders include partners where students may be placed in practica and internship experiences. These stakeholders also have a vested interest in student success.

Summary and Vision

Despite piecemeal efforts to improve experiences for historically underrepresented students, there is little change in patterns of academic success and degree attainment. Based on demographic trends alone, if we continue along this pathway, it will surely lead to a national crisis. We must address the cultural gap between the culture of higher education and diverse students' cultures. Further, the cultural gaps between the students and faculty will continue unless there are significant increases in diverse faculties and *cultural competence* among all faculties and improved enculturation processes for students.

Learning to navigate the university culture is challenging enough for faculty and staff. Imagine what it's like for culturally diverse students, especially those who are first in their families to attend. They have a distinct disadvantage in navigating and interpreting this new, foreign cultural context called *higher education*, unless successfully mentored.

If diversity is truly valued and appreciated as a benefit to all students and the institution, then a much more proactive, comprehensive, and collaborative approach to diversity is needed. It is also time to recognize the cultural values and experiences diverse students bring with them as institutional assets, *rather than deficiencies*.

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